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The Lahore Resolution of 1940 and Its Impacts on the Muslim League Policy

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Abstract
The Lahore Resolution, commonly known as the Pakistan Resolution which was moved in the Lahore Session of The All India Muslim League in the year 1940 is a landmark event with regard to the future of the Indian union and the partition of India. This was the event which actually gave the Muslim League a firm ground upon which their demand for the separate state for the Muslim people of India grew. The popularity of the League also grew by many folds. The Two-Nation Theory got the momentum from this time onwards and eventually in 1947 the partition of India was taken place on the basis of religion.

Keywords: Lahore Resolution, the Muslim League, communalism, partition of India

The Lahore Resolution was moved in the year 1940 at the Lahore session of the All India Muslim League. This resolution later came to be known as the Pakistan Resolution. This was a milestone event with regard to the future of the Muslims in India in general and the Bengali Muslims in particular. It bore a very significant consequence and decided the fate of the Muslims in India. Fazlul Huq, the Chief Minister of Bengal and the leader of the Bengal Provincial Muslim League played a significant role in the session by moving the Lahore Resolution.

Mohammad Ali Jinnah was the person who called a general session of the All India Muslim League in Lahore to discuss the situation that had arisen due to the outbreak of the Second World War and the Government of India participating in the War without taking proper opinion of the Indian leaders. Another agenda of the session was to analyze the reasons that led to the defeat of the Muslim League in the general election of 1937 in the Muslim majority provinces. Jinnah in his speech, criticized the Congress and the nationalist Muslims and voiced for the Two-Nation Theory and the reasons for the demand for separate Muslim homeland. The stand of Jinnah had an immediate effect on the Muslim masses.

Sikandar Hayat Khan, the Chief Minister of the Punjab, drafted the original Lahore Resolution, which was placed before the Subject Committee of the All India Muslim League for discussion and amendments. The Resolution, which was significantly amended by the Subject Committee, was moved in the general session by Fazlul Huq on 23 March and was supported by Choudhury Khaliquzzaman and other Muslim leaders. The

Lahore Resolution called for independent states as seen by the statement—"That geographically contiguous units are demarcated regions which should be constituted, with such territorial readjustments as may be necessary that the areas in which Muslims are numerically in a majority as in the North Western and Eastern zones of (British) India should be grouped to constitute 'independent states' in which the constituent units should be autonomous and sovereign." Although, the name 'Pakistan' had been proposed by Choudhury Rahmat Ali in his Pakistan Declaration[1] it was not until after the resolution it began to be widely used.

From the speeches made by various speakers on the occasion, it was evident that though all of them accepted the idea of a separate state for Muslims. Fazlul Huq's approach was different from that of Jinnah and others. Fazlul Huq, in his opinion thought that the Indian Muslims were weak. Even in the Muslim majority provinces, their opinion and stand was not unanimous. They were not united enough to make a single decision themselves. He thought that if all the Muslims in India were concentrated in one area, there would have been no reason to fear. But contrary to this, the Muslims in India were scattered to various areas. Unless this problem was solved, any talk about constitutional developments and safeguards would be meaningless. Therefore, in his speech at the session, Fazlul Huq did not propagate the Two-Nation Theory as Jinnah and other leaders did.

Fazlul Huq thought that a separate state for Muslims was necessary for the progress of the Indian Muslims who were backward and scattered. Interestingly, none of the Muslim leaders of Bengal were ever reported for being associated with any of the schemes propounded at the time for the creation of Pakistan. Neither Huq nor any other Bengali Muslim was associated with the political discussions that started after the Sind Provincial Muslim League proposal of 1938 for self-rule for Hindu and Muslims separately.[2] Perhaps the very fact that Bengal was not associated with these schemes for the creation of Pakistan prompted Jinnah to call upon Fazlul Huq to move the resolution. However, after the resolution was passed the Muslim leaders of Bengal gathered under the banner of the Muslim League and worked hard for the popularization of the Pakistan demand.

Mohammad Ali Jinnah's address to the Lahore Conference was the moment when Jinnah, a former proponent of Hindu-Muslim unity, irrevocably transformed himself into the leader of the movement for an independent Pakistan.

Making the common will for the achievement of Pakistan or a separate homeland for the Muslim populace was a must for which the Muslim League had been making efforts ever since its inception. This objective at last became fruitful in the form of Lahore Resolution. This resolution not only affected the future of the Indian Muslims but changed the direction of South Asian politics radically. The Lahore Resolution shattered the dream of nationalists for the consolidated India (Akhand Bharat). The concept of Muslim League was altogether changed after the Lahore Resolution and now it was not a political party, but it emerged as peoples' party which makes the establishment of Pakistan possible on the basis of majority demand and strength of

[1] The Pakistan Declaration was a pamphlet written and published by Choudhury Rahmat Ali on 28 January 1933, in which the word 'Pakistan' was used for the first time

[2] Khaleed Bin Sayeed, Pakistan: The Formation Phase, (Karachi, 1968) p. 200

Muslims. After the resolution, a large number of Muslims started joining the Muslim League. The demand for a Muslim state was taken as the best solution to the Muslim-non-Muslim communalism in India. Whether the Indian Muslims fell in the Muslim majority areas or not, they seemed enlightened with the idea of a independent, standard and prosperous life of their co-religious people. Urban as well as the rural areas stood behind the demand for Muslim state. The League's influence in the Muslim rural areas was growing rapidly and the people were zealously ready to register themselves as the League members.

The All India Azad Muslim Conference[3] gathered in Delhi in April 1940 and opposed the proposal made in the Lahore Session of the League and showed their support for an independent and united India. The members of the organization included several Islamic organizations in India, as well as 1400 nationalist Muslim delegates. The All India Muslim League tried to silence those nationalist Muslims who voiced against the partition of India by all means possible. The murder of the Chief Minister of Sind and All India Azad Muslim Conference leader, Allah Baksh Soomro also made the fob much easier for All India Muslim League.

Impacts of Lahore Resolution:

Impact of Lahore Resolution was mainly felt with the high level criticism made by Indian Congress, Hindu Mahasabha and Sikh leaders. There had been number of allegations over the demand for new state of Pakistan made by Jinnah. The Lahore Resolution came at a time when the Indian politics was going through a period of political stalement All the league leaders were engaged their own local politics .As far as Jinnah's position was concerned the congress had ignored its relevance during its Patna and Ramgarh session and even Linlithgow was tired of Jinnah's political thrills and suggested Jinnah to find some constructive methods for political settlement in India.

Muhammad Ali Jinnah's demand for the state of Pakistan was heavily rejected and condemned by the Indian National Congress, Hindu Mahasabha and the Sikhs. The demand for Pakistan directly affected the entire Indian union of India particularly the states which were claimed to be divided within two nations. The most prominent among them was the state of Punjab which had half of its population living in west Punjab to be divided towards Pakistan and Bengal with a huge number of people staying in east Bengal. The state of Bengal had a majority of Muslim population living in West Bengal. Hence, it was heavily condemned by the Sikhs who would have to surrender their place of holy land to Muslim domination. Rajagopalachari condemned the resolution as a mischief mainly intended to threaten India of the consequent destruction to be followed on. Hindu Mahasabha rejected the resolution by claiming that it was a step closer towards a civil war within two nations on the basis of religion. While the British kept silent on the issue as it would serve to their

[3] The All India Azad Muslim Conference, commonly called the Azad Muslim Conference was an organization of nationalist Muslims in India, who were opposing the partition of India and were advocating the composite nationalism and united India

policy of divide and rule, Congress under Jawaharlal Nehru declared that it had nothing to do with mad proposals of Muslim League.

In spite of its mass rejection and condemnation the resolution remained at the crux of Muslim politics which did not demoralise Jinnah who fought for it till the end. As for the reaction of the Muslims from the Muslim majority region the idea of division was not confirmed expression of political aspiration of a strong Muslim communal nationality from below. Nevertheless the evidences never rejected the fact that the Lahore Resolution had changed the political complexion of the Indian subcontinent. The political ramifications at the provincial level marked the fact that the resolution could not be rejected or ignored for long. It further changed the political complexion of Punjab who was forced to have an unpredictable future in front of them. Moreover the status of the Sikhs also came under doubt where the Sikhs were the Sikhs were in minority.

In Lahore Resolution, the phrase "independent states" is used instead of "independent state" in the context. The presence of 's' with the word state in the original text becomes significant in context of 1971 secession of East Pakistan to become Bangladesh. It has been argued that the initial intention was to form many individual states in the areas where Muslims were in majority rather than single state for the Muslims of India. The fact that the resolution was presented by a Bengali nationalist, Fazlul Huq, adds weight to the argument that according to the resolution, East Pakistan was never supposed to be the part of Pakistan.

The Lahore Resolution gave the Muslim League a great fillip after the devastating result in the 1937 election where it only won few seats which were reserved for Muslims in Sind, Punjab, Bengal, Baluchistan and NWFP and within six years of time, it changed the whole complexion with the overwhelming success of the Muslim League in 1946 election, when it won 425 out of 496 seats reserved for the Muslims. This grand success prepared the platform for the Muslim League to create Pakistan. The momentum generated by the passage of the Lahore Resolution allowed the Muslims to build a huge support and rally the Muslims of sub-continent for the demand of independent state of Pakistan.

All this bring us to believe that the Lahore resolution was the first resolution which had the vision for a new nation of Pakistan .This gave some respite to Jinnah to create a strong hold in Indian politics. As for the nationalist leaders in India it only began anew episode of conflict which lasted till the end. The All India Muslim League Resolution of March 1940, commonly known as the Pakistan Resolution, is undoubtedly the most important event that changed the course of Indian history and left deep marks on world history. With the passage of this Resolution, the Muslims of the sub-continent changed their demand from "Separate Electorates" to a "Separate State". This Resolution rejected the idea of a United India and the creation of an independent Muslim state was set as their ultimate goal. It gave new energy and courage to the Muslims of the region who gathered around the dynamic leadership of Jinnah from the platform of the Muslim League to struggle for their freedom. The able leadership of Mohammad Ali Jinnah and the commitment and devotion of

the followers made it possible for them to achieve an independent state within seven years of their struggle in the form of Pakistan.

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